

A WEEKEND PROJECT

Teaching a tool to someone who has never opened it

I learned Whatfix (Community edition) and built in-app guidance for Google Data Studio: a 12-step walkthrough, a Beacon, and a Self Help panel.

Alisha Chaudhari · Digital adoption / Product

The problem I was solving

Google Data Studio is free and powerful. It is also a blank canvas, and a blank canvas is where new users quit.

So I did not document the product. I picked the single journey that makes the tool click — getting your own data onto a page and seeing it become a chart — and built guidance for that one journey.

Rule I worked to: guide the task that is high-volume or expensive to get wrong. Let the obvious stuff go.

Three pieces

01 Walkthrough

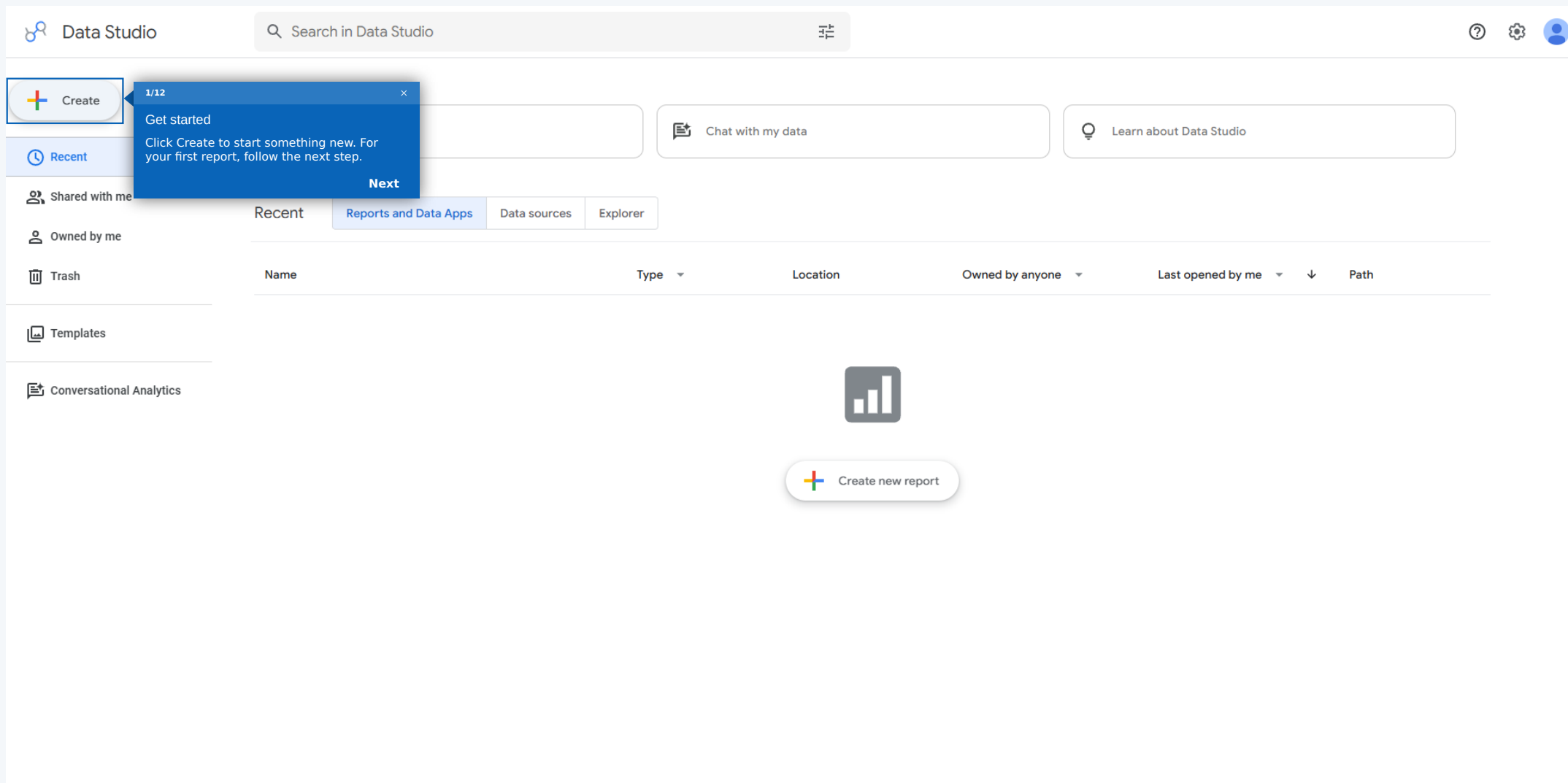
12 steps, from the Create button to sharing the finished report.

02 Top 5 flows

The next five journeys a beginner needs, ordered as a funnel.

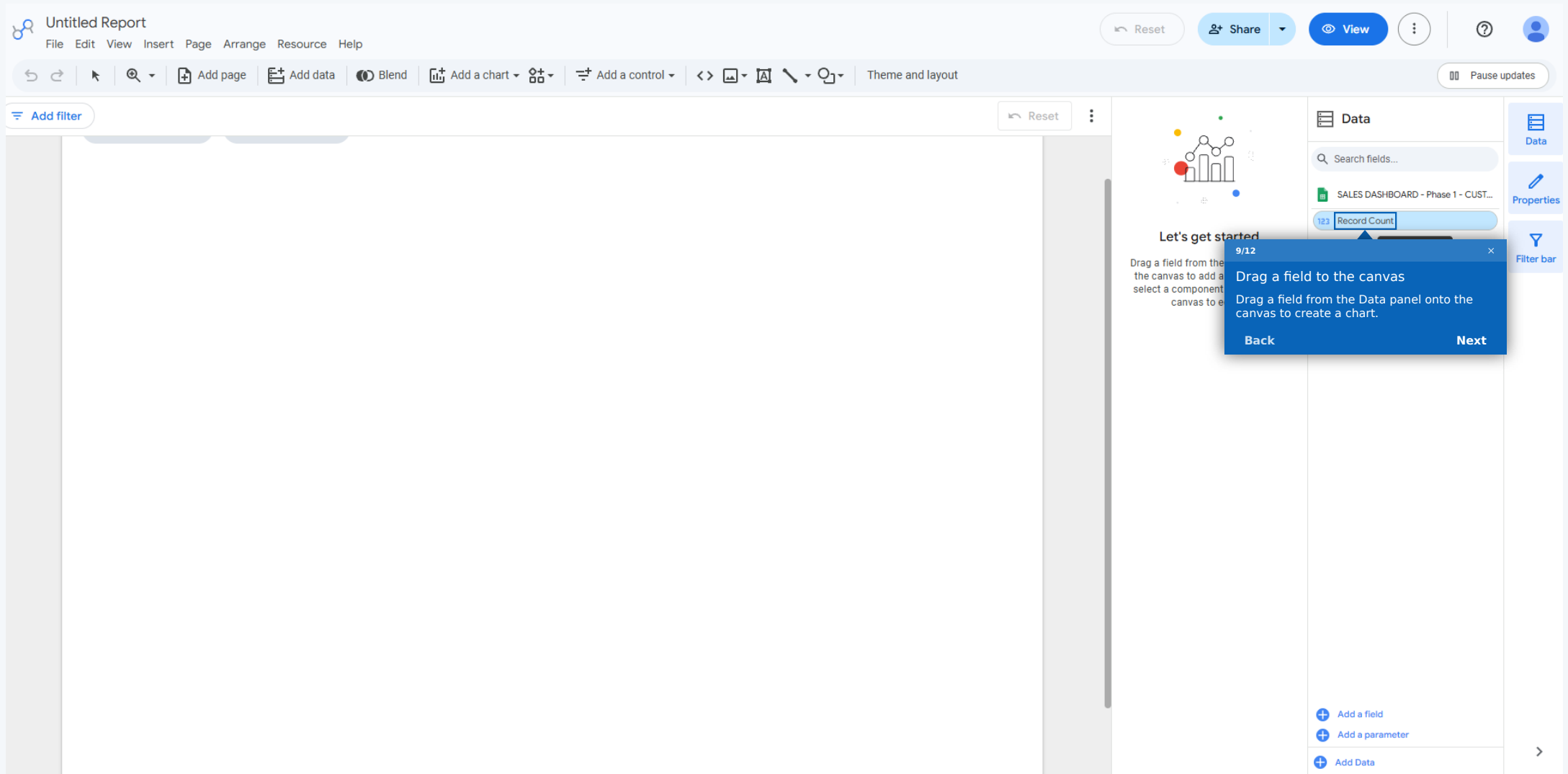
03 Beacon + Self Help

One nudge to a feature people miss, and a help panel so the guidance never runs out.



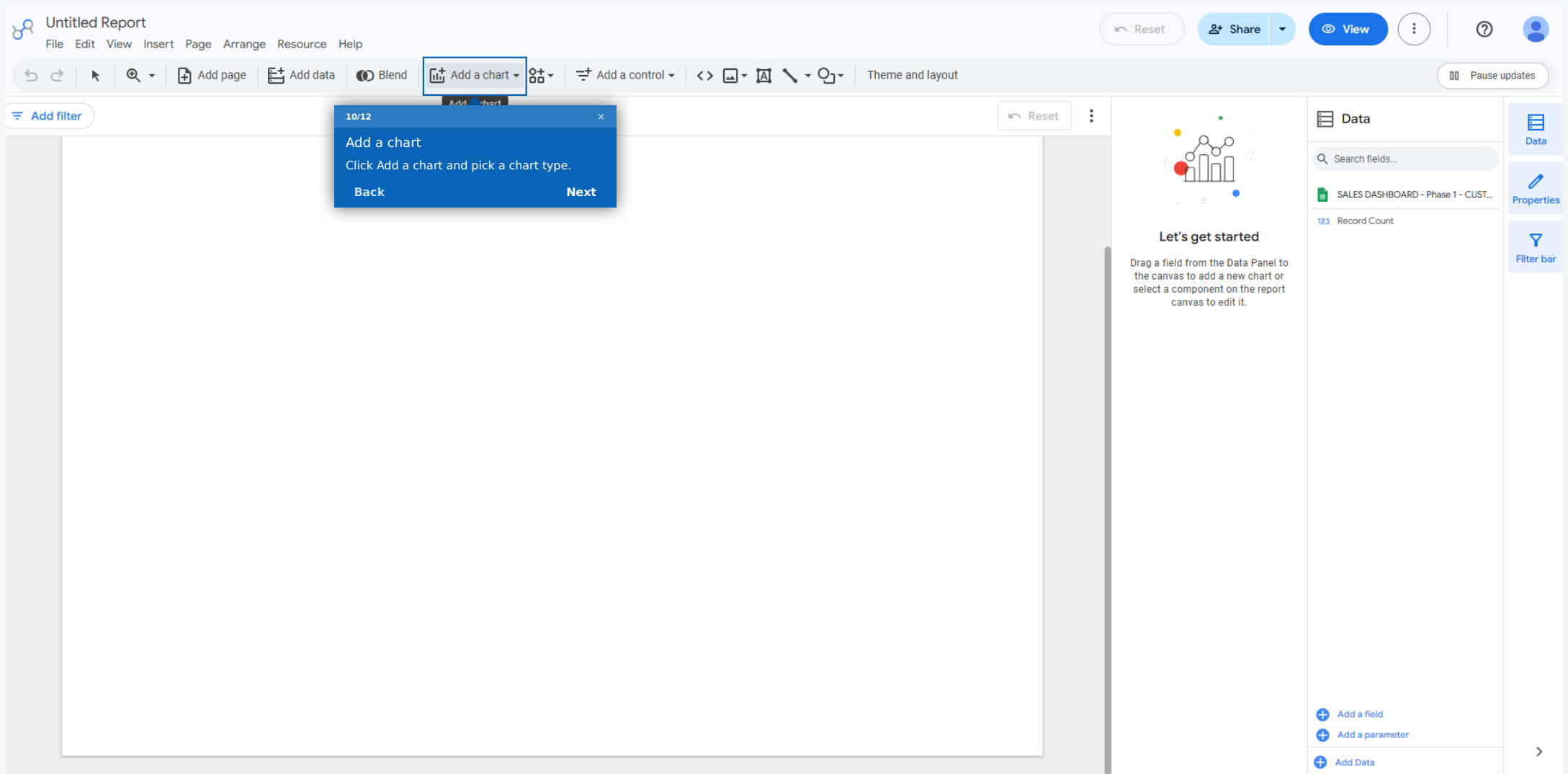
Step 1 of 12 — start where every new user lands.

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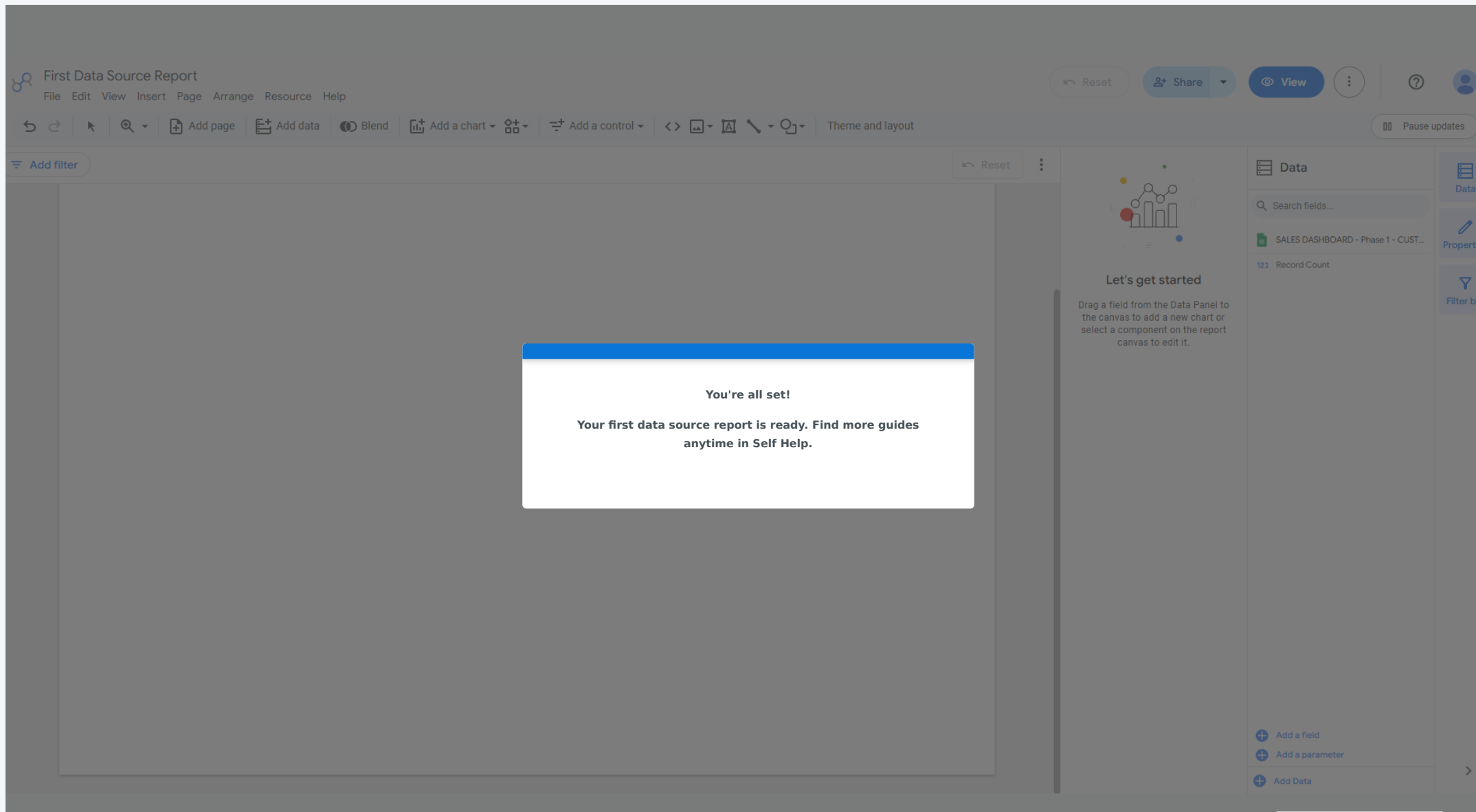
Step 9 of 12 — drag a field onto the canvas and the data becomes something you can see.

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Step 10 of 12 — add a chart. This is the moment the tool clicks.

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The end screen hands the user over to Self Help, so help does not stop when the tour does.

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Top 5 flows for a new user

Ordered as a funnel, not as a menu — each one is the next place a beginner gets stuck.

1. Create your first report

The aha moment. Users who build one report early come back.

2. Connect and manage a data source

Where almost every "my numbers look wrong" ticket begins.

3. Start from a template

Beginners freeze at a blank canvas. Templates show good design.

4. Add charts and controls

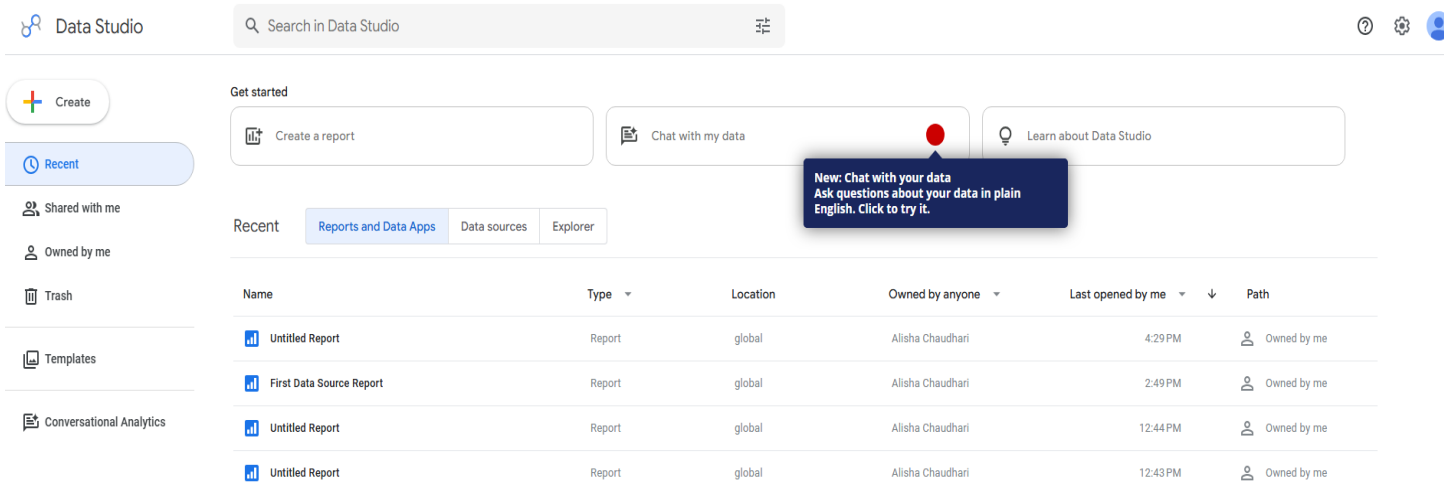
Filters turn a static page into something people explore.

5. Share and schedule

A report nobody sees has no value. Scheduling builds the habit.

Beacon

A pulsing hotspot that draws the eye to one element, without blocking the user.



Example: A beacon on the "Chat with my data" card tells users about this new feature on the Data Studio home page.

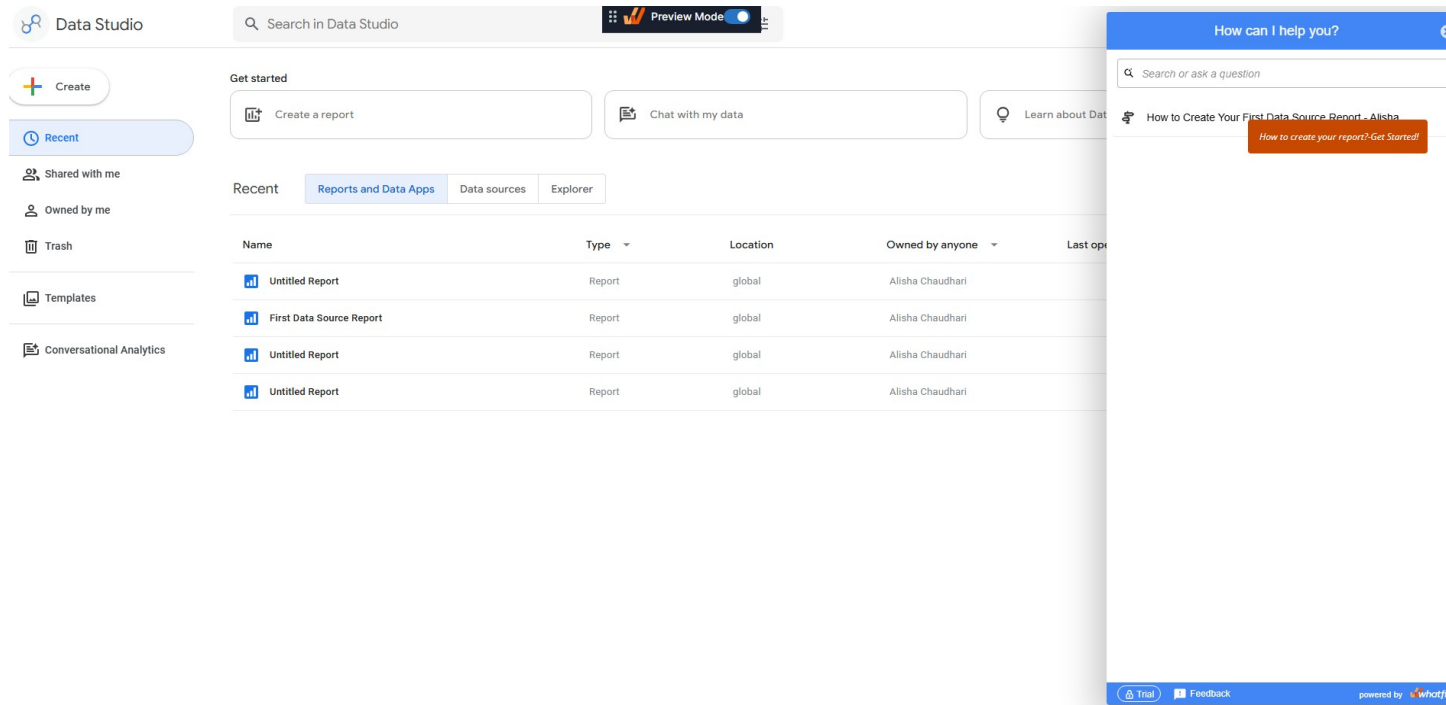
Use cases

- **Highlight a new feature:** point users to something new, like "Chat with my data".
- **Promote a useful feature:** remind users about tools they often miss, like Templates or Schedule delivery.
- **Show what changed:** mark a button or menu that moved or looks different after an update.
- **Offer more help:** let users click the beacon to start a step-by-step guide.

Set-up in Whatfix: Studio → Beacon → select "Chat with my data" → add tooltip text → set visibility (Data Studio domain; shows when the card is on screen; all users; up to 5 times) → Save.

Self Help

An in-app help widget: users search and launch guides, articles and videos without leaving Data Studio.



Example: The Self Help panel on the Data Studio home page lists the "How to Create Your First Data Source Report" walkthrough.

Use cases

- **Help at the moment of need:** users can ask questions like "How do I create a report?" without leaving Data Studio.
- **All help in one place:** walkthroughs, help articles and videos sit in a single panel.
- **Faster start, fewer tickets:** new users build their first report on their own, so they send fewer support requests.
- **Right help on the right page:** each page can show only the guides that fit it, like report guides inside the report editor.

Set-up in Whatfix: Dashboard → Widget → Create Widget → Self Help → add the walkthrough → set visibility (URL contains datastudio.google.com) → Save.

What I would measure next

- Completion rate of the walkthrough — and the exact step people quit at.
- Time to first report created, per new user.
- Support questions about building a report, before and after.
- Help searches that return nothing — that list is the next thing to write.

Content without a number attached is just documentation with animation.

What I took away

Building the guidance was the fast part. Deciding what to leave out took longer than recording the steps.

Software is not hard to buy. It is hard to get used.

Full write-up and files: github.com/ALISHA-19

Built with the Whatfix Community edition. Not affiliated with Whatfix or Google.